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News

Matt de Ferranti becomes new Arlington County Board chair for 2026

By **Scott McCaffrey**

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County Board Chair Matt de Ferranti (screenshot via Arlington County)

Matt de Ferranti is the new chair of Arlington County Board for 2026, while Maureen Coffey is the new vice-chair.

De Ferranti, who was first elected in 2018 and who [previously held the chairmanship](#) in 2021, used his remarks last night (Monday) to tout a local government that can be responsive to community needs and fight for local values while being prudent with taxpayer funds.

“We must be fiscally responsible for the long term” but also “invest wisely now to counteract [the economy we have](#),” de Ferranti said at the Board’s [annual organizational meeting](#).

De Ferranti, who succeeded Takis Karantonis as chair, said he would use the upcoming year to focus on four priority areas:

- “Policies that stabilize our economy and position us for recovery”
- “Protecting and serving our most vulnerable”
- “Keeping our community safe”
- “Protecting the investments that make Arlington a great place to live — our environment, our schools and our children”

Questions about the region’s economic future and impacts on the county’s tax revenue are likely to significantly impact decisions during the upcoming budget season, de Ferranti said.

“Our budget will not likely allow big new investments, much as we might like it,” he said. “There will not be any easy choices.”

“We’re in a tough moment,” de Ferranti said.

The new Board chair said the body would work with incoming Gov. Abigail Spanberger (D) and Democratic majorities in the General Assembly.

“This is a moment. We have to grab it and we have to take advantage of it,” de Ferranti said.

He said county leaders would fight Trump administration efforts targeting groups ranging from the federal workforce to the immigrant community.

An attorney who grew up in McLean, de Ferranti was [elected to the County Board](#) in 2018, unseating incumbent John Vihstadt.

He was re-elected in 2022 and has suggested, but not formally announced, plans to run for reelection this year. Like his four colleagues, de Ferranti is a Democrat.

In turning over the gavel at the Jan. 5 meeting, Karantonis said de Ferranti’s seven years in elected office had created a “steady decision-maker” who “worked with everybody for common, good outcomes.”

“It’s very important to be a good team player” while retaining independence of thought, Karantonis said — adding that de Ferranti fit the bill.



2026 County Board Vice-Chair Maureen Coffey (screenshot via Arlington County)

Coffey, the new vice-chair, will rotate in as chair in 2027, assuming all goes as is typical.

“I really appreciate the confidence,” Coffey said after being nominated by colleague Susan Cunningham.

Coffey already served — if briefly — as acting chair. During the summer, she filled the role when Karantonis was in Europe on a Sister Cities trip and de Ferranti was away on paternity leave.

With the [reelection of Karantonis](#) in November, there is no change to the existing lineup among Board members: de Ferranti, Coffey, Karantonis, Cunningham and Julius “J.D.” Spain Sr. Each had the opportunity to list priorities for the coming year at the meeting.

The crowd for the organizational meeting was modest, lower than the norm when the Board had held its organizational meetings on [New Year's Day](#). That tradition was phased out a decade ago, with the organizational meetings moving to later in the first week of the new year.

While Board members in December opted to defer consideration of creating a change-of-government task force back, the issue will return in the summer as promised, de Ferranti said.

“We have an opportunity to move the conversation forward,” he said of the change-of-governance issue.

[Regular Saturday Board meetings](#) are scheduled to be held Jan. 24, Feb. 21, March 14, April 18, May 16, June 13, July 18, Sept. 19, Oct. 17, Nov. 14 and Dec. 12 this year.

Recessed meetings will be held on subsequent Tuesdays with the exception of June, when the follow-up meeting will be held the subsequent Wednesday.

As is typical, Board members have not scheduled meetings for August.

No change to ‘one-speaker-per-topic’ rule for public comment: Board members on Jan. 5 voted to maintain the longstanding policy of hearing only one speaker on any given topic during the public-comment period that begins Board meetings on Saturdays.

Despite calls from some in the public for a less restrictive policy, de Ferranti said it was kept owing to “the need to maintain an efficient Saturday business meeting for all involved.”

To address complaints about the restrictive nature of the comment period, Board members did slate a pair of “town hall” meetings for Mondays, May 4 and Oct. 26 at 6:30 p.m.

Although details have not been released, there will be no one-speaker-per-topic rule for those meetings, de Ferranti said.

Maintaining existing rules for public comment at Board meetings but adding the town-hall meetings “feels like a good compromise,” Cunningham said.

“We can always change it later if we need to,” she said.

No ‘tie-breaker’ for 2026: Board members on Jan. 5 also voted not to appoint a county resident as [tie-breaker](#) in case members should split 2-2 with one not voting.

Virginia law gives localities the power to tap a county resident to serve that function. In the Board’s 93-year history, it does not appear anyone has ever been selected to fill the role.

About the Author



Scott McCaffrey

A Northern Virginia native, Scott McCaffrey has four decades of reporting, editing and newsroom experience in the local area plus Florida, South Carolina and the eastern panhandle of West Virginia. He spent 26 years as editor of the Sun Gazette newspaper chain. For Local News Now, he covers government and civic issues in Arlington, Fairfax County and Falls Church.

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